

Practice Paper 24 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — “The loudest silent room”

1 mark for identifying that the description is a **paradox / oxymoron** (the hall is silent yet feels noisy).

1 mark for explaining that the **small sounds** — ticking clocks, a cough — feel **amplified** and **intense** because of the enforced quiet, creating a **tense, pressured atmosphere**.

Q2. [1] — Strict discipline

1 mark for any **one** of:

- A single cough caused the player to be “**glared at by half the room**”.
- The clocks ticked **out of step**, suggesting players were focused only on their own boards.
- Players are expected to remain **silent** throughout.

Q3. [2] — “A small, polite fire to your house”

1 mark — The comparison suggests Voss is **outwardly calm and well-mannered** (“polite”), so his aggression is **not loud or obvious**.

1 mark — Yet his play is **quietly destructive** — like a fire, his attacks **spread and ruin** the opponent’s position before they can be stopped.

Q4. [1] — Hands in lap

1 mark — She is **trembling with nerves** and does not want the watching hall (or her opponent) to see that she is **frightened** / lacking in confidence.

Q5. [2] — “As though it belonged to someone else”

1 mark — The narrator feels **detached** / **disconnected** from her own body.

1 mark — This suggests she is **acting on memorised preparation** rather than fully present thought; she is so **nervous** that her movements feel **automatic** / **mechanical**.

Q6. [2] — Complicated and dangerous position

1 mark each for any two of:

- The position was “**untidy**” with “**pieces tangled in the centre**”.
- “**Both kings still uncastled**” — both kings were exposed.
- “**Threats running in three directions**” — attacks coming from multiple angles.
- Her knight was “**on the rim of the board where... knights did not belong**” (a poor square).
- Voss had an “**attacking formation that turned annotated games into short ones**” (a deadly attack).

Q7. [2] — “A doubt the size of a small stone”

1 mark — The **metaphor** compares an abstract feeling (doubt) to a **physical, tangible object** (a stone), making it feel **real** and **heavy**.

1 mark — The word “**settled**” and the choice of **stone** suggest the doubt is **small but solid** — it cannot be argued away, and its physical weight in her chest mirrors her growing anxiety.

Q8. [1] — “Indifferent” clock

1 mark — **Personification**: the clock is given a human attitude (uncaring); it suggests the narrator feels **alone** and **unsupported** — even time itself does not care whether she finds the right move.

Q9. [2] — “Loneliness of being unhelpable”

1 mark — It is the loneliness of being in a situation where **no one is allowed to help**, even those who want to.

1 mark — Others may **see** her struggle and even **understand** it, but the **rules of the game** and the **nature of the decision** mean the responsibility falls **entirely on her alone**.

Reject answers that merely lift “the loneliness of being unhelpable”.

Q10. [2] — “The careful nothing”

1 mark — The phrase suggests the coach is **deliberately** showing **no expression** — his neutral face is a **conscious effort**, not a natural state.

1 mark — It implies that he is **holding back emotion** (concern, encouragement) because the **rules forbid him** from helping; the **care** lies in his self-control.

Q11. [3] — “Cold, clean sort of clarity”

(a) [1]: She felt a sudden, **calm certainty** — her fear had been replaced by a **clear, undeniable understanding** that her calculation was correct.

(b) [2]:

- **1 mark** — The device is **alliteration** (repetition of the hard “c” sound in **cold, clean, clarity**).

- **1 mark** — The crisp, clipped sound mirrors the **sharp, decisive nature** of the realisation; it makes the clarity feel **precise** and **unsentimental**, almost surgical.

(Also accept **consonance** / **triple adjective listing** with a sensible explanation of effect.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — “A faint odour of compromise”

1 mark — **Odour of compromise** suggests something **slightly unpleasant** / **not quite respectable** — a hint of **settling for less**.

1 mark — It implies that buying second-hand was once seen as **inferior** to buying new, something a serious luxury buyer would **prefer to hide** or **avoid**.

Q13. [2] — Growth of the market

1 mark each for any two of:

- The market has **tripled in size since 2017**.
- Resale is growing **roughly four times as quickly** as the primary luxury market.
- By the end of the decade, **almost one in five** luxury items sold worldwide is expected to be pre-owned.

Q14. [2] — Old shop vs the app era

1 mark each for any two of:

- Listing an item is now **quick and easy** (a phone photograph) rather than slow.
- **Authentication** is now done **for the seller** by the platform.
- **Payment** is **rapid** (a few days) rather than uncertain.
- The transaction is now **public and glamorous** rather than **private and slightly embarrassing**.

Reject answers that merely lift “slow and slightly furtive”.

Q15. [1] — Exclusivity supporting detail

1 mark for any **one** of:

- A **discontinued model**.
- A **colour no longer produced**.
- A **sold-out collaboration**.
- These become **the only way in** — the resale platform is the **sole route** to obtain them.

Q16. [2] — Use of “paradoxically”

1 mark — A **paradox** is something that **seems contradictory**; one would normally expect a used item to **lose** value over time, not gain it.

1 mark — The word draws attention to the **surprising fact** that some luxury items behave like **investments** rather than ordinary goods, **increasing** in value despite being second-hand.

Q17. [2] — Two responses of the luxury houses

1 mark — **Publicly**, they have **embraced** resale by launching their **own authenticated resale channels** (and even repurchasing items).

1 mark — **Privately**, they continue to **fight** the wider resale market in court because they want

to **retain control** over how their products are **priced and presented**; both responses serve the same goal of **protecting the brand**.

Q18. [1] — Inverted commas around “Certified Pre-Owned”

1 mark — The inverted commas mark this as the **official term / brand label** used by the watchmaker (a **specific, named programme**), not the writer’s own phrase. (Also accept: it draws attention to a **new piece of jargon** that has entered the industry.)

Q19. [2] — Why authenticity is difficult

1 mark each for any two of:

- The **counterfeit industry has grown alongside** resale, becoming more sophisticated.
- “**Superfakes**” are so well made that even **trained authenticators** struggle to spot them.
- Even with **AI-assisted authentication**, **mistakes happen**.
- A wrongly authenticated item can pass through **several owners** before the error is caught.

Q20. [2] — Effect of listing financial expressions

1 mark — The **cumulative listing** of financial language (**portfolios, assets, rotated**) creates a **striking impression** that younger buyers think about clothing in **investment terms**.

1 mark — It **reinforces the writer’s argument** that the older idea of **ownership** has been replaced by something closer to **trading**; the rhythm of the list also gives the sentence a **brisk, businesslike feel**.

Q21. [2] — “Asked... to mean it”

(a) [1]: **Wry / pointed / ironic / quietly challenging**. (Reject: angry, bitter, mocking.)

(b) [1]: The houses long **claimed** that their products would **last forever**; now, with resale flourishing, they must **prove** that promise is true — items must genuinely **endure many owners** and **hold their value over time**.

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points (½ mark each, max 6 marks). **Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.**

Why second-hand luxury appeals to younger buyers (Paragraphs 3 and 6):

1. **Better value / lower price** — a pre-owned item can cost up to forty per cent less than new.
2. **Sustainability / environmental concern** — a smaller environmental footprint than buying new.
3. **Exclusivity** — access to discontinued models, retired colours or sold-out collaborations otherwise unobtainable.
4. A **flexible relationship with ownership** — items can be worn, resold, and most of the cost recouped, treated as **assets** rather than possessions.

Concerns and difficulties created by the resale boom (Paragraphs 4 and 5):

5. Luxury houses **lose control** over how their products are priced and presented.
6. The **counterfeit industry** has grown alongside resale, in increasingly sophisticated ways.

7. **“Superfakes”** are so well made that even **trained authenticators** can be deceived.
8. **Authentication mistakes** can pass undetected through **several owners** before discovery.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

Younger buyers are drawn to second-hand luxury because it is significantly cheaper, less wasteful, and offers access to rare or discontinued pieces unavailable new. Many also treat items as flexible assets, worn for a while and resold to recover most of the cost. However, the boom troubles brands who lose control of pricing, and authenticity has become harder to guarantee: counterfeiters now produce near-perfect fakes that fool trained experts, and undetected errors can spread through several owners.

Length count: 78 words from “Younger” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —